

Photographs by SANJAY SONKAR



SCIENTISTS AND TEACHERS OF NDATU PROTEST OUTSIDE THE CAMPUS

Freezing the FUTURE

Denial of wages forces scientists and teachers at three agricultural universities to go on strike, crippling crucial research that could help the state's farmers

By Subhash Mishra

For years, even through its many political ups and downs, Uttar Pradesh has played a pivotal role in attaining food security for the nation. The three agricultural universities in the state have developed more than 250 high-yielding varieties of wheat, rice, pulses, oil seeds, vegetables, forage, sugarcane and fruit crops to enhance farm produce and increase profitability.

But hundreds of scientists,

researchers and teachers working in the field of agricultural education and technology have been literally left starving. The laboratories in which they should have been working to develop new technology and seeds to assist the farmers in increasing their produce have been closed. The green farms which were supposed to be models for farmers have withered away. This is the pathetic state of affairs in the agricultural universities of the state, where the teachers, the scientists and the non-teaching staff have

been on strike for the last three months as they are being denied wages and funds. For more than a decade, the state government has frozen grants to them, crippling the functioning of the universities completely to the extent of stalling all research and development. University officials at the prestigious Narendra Dev Agriculture and Technology University (NDATU), Faizabad, went on strike in November in protest against the criminal neglect by the state Government. Now the officials of the Sardar Vallabh Bhai Patel University of Agriculture and Technology, Modipuram, Meerut, have also joined the strike and the staff of the Chandra Shekhar Azad University of Agriculture and Technology, Kanpur, are expected to join in. "We were directly catering to more than 30 districts of the state and nearly 10 crore farmers," says Dr Ram Pratap Singh, president, NDATU.

Ram claimed that a delegation had met the state governor, B.L. Joshi, who has sought a report from the state Government and also ordered it to look into the demands of the university officials. Highly-placed sources in Raj Bhavan say that Joshi will ask the state